

Could
technology
allow me to
indefinitely
delay death?

For biological systems, death seems inevitable. Biological systems age and decay over time, and there is (so far as we know) no way to prevent this from happening.

Recent technological developments, though, have led many to pose the question of whether we might be able to indefinitely delay death, not by stopping or slowing the biological aging process, but by escaping our biological nature entirely.

We might attempt to do this by becoming, not biological systems, but synthetic artificially intelligent systems.

‘Artificial intelligence’ is a term for the ability of machines to perform tasks intelligently: for example, to strategize and to solve problems.

Suppose that it is the year 2045. We have now developed silicon devices which replicate but improve upon the functioning of neurons or clusters of neurons. The silicon devices do just the same things as the neurons they replace, but more quickly and more efficiently.

We might attempt to do this by becoming, not biological systems, but synthetic artificially intelligent systems. This possibility has been taken increasingly seriously in recent decades. A central idea of the transhumanist movement has been that advances in computing power will, as early as a few decades from now, make 'whole brain emulation,' or 'uploading,' possible. This would involve the creation of a digital replica of a human brain, which would preserve its memories, personality, and consciousness.

The brain contains about 90 billion neurons. Uploading is well beyond the capacities of current computers. But with continued rapid increases in computing power, it may well become possible.

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So defined, artificial intelligence is nowhere and us. There

are plenty of examples of AI systems which are vastly better

than humans at performing various tasks.

an artificial intelligence capable of doing all or almost all

of the things that ordinary adult humans can do.

What does not yet exist is a general artificial intelligence:

artificial intelligence.

No machine in existence (that we know of) has general

pathway which may include choices which will be available to

Today we will discuss one way in which you might be com

non-biological entity with general artificial intelligence — a

you in your lifetime.

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